when pressure was applied, but the release of being able to manage him allowed me to concentrate on my batting.

We'd had more than three weeks to acclimatize. I failed in the first warm-up game, but something clicked when I scored a century in the second, at Adelaide. It never ceases to amaze me how confidence feeds off itself, so that it feels self-generated. I scored another ton in the final warm-up; I had averaged 26.21 in ten Tests against Australia up until then, compared to an overall Test average of 42.78, but I felt ready.

Looking back, that first morning marked a turning point. It was the first time in my career that I consciously stood up to the pressure. I delivered. I picked the length. I refused to dart at anything wide and waited patiently for anything steered into my pads. It wasn't a flawless innings, a copybook century. I was dropped at point by Xavier Doherty on 26, and had made 67 when I was fifth out, setting up a hat-trick by my current Essex teammate Peter Siddle.

Most immediately, my feeling of freedom helped sustain our spoiling operation once Australia had taken a 221-run first-innings lead. The fallout from the final ball of the fourth day was another indication that I belonged. Though my execution was nothing special – a full toss by Doherty despatched through a big gap for the boundary that took me to 132 not out – I was operating on another level.

When you are on that sort of score overnight, you allow yourself a Happy Hour. It's a very special feeling. You know you are delivering. You allow yourself the luxury of enjoying the warmth of the welcome back to the dressing room, and scroll through the congratulatory messages on your phone without getting carried away by the back-slapping. You permit yourself the simple pleasure of a beer, and burger and chips.

There are not many days like that in Test cricket, so make the most of them. I went to bed around 9 p.m., absolutely knackered from being on the field almost four days straight, but woke before midnight, and never got back to sleep because my mind was racing. When I got up the next morning, that familiar ache, in the pit of the stomach, reminded me it was time to do it all again.

Cricket is like snooker, in that the trick is being able to reset after periods of inactivity. A snooker player is defined by his production in the World Championship, where games can extend to more than ten hours over two days. He needs the discipline to avoid concocting disastrous scenarios when